'Night Mother

By Marsha Norman

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Suicide takes the lives of nearly 40,000 Americans every year.*
ACTRESS 2: *And although the reasons why vary from individual to individual, it remains an act that survivors struggle to understand regardless of the reasons.*
ACTRESS 1: *In Night Mother by Marsha Norman, we experience the complete resolve of one young woman, Jessie, who has chosen to end her life*
ACTRESS 2: *And her mother, who spends the last evening alone with her daughter*
TOGETHER: *Night Mother by Marsha Norman*

JESSIE: **(Pg 9-11)** We got any old towels? *(holding a towel that was on the stack of newspapers)* Towels you don't want any more. How about this swimming towel Loretta gave us? Beach towel, that's the name of it. You want it? *(Mama shakes her head No.)* And a big piece of plastic like a rubber sheet or something. Garbage bags would do if there's enough.

THELMA: Don't go making a big mess, Jessie. It's eight o'clock already. Your hair is black enough, hon.

JESSIE: *(continues to search the kitchen cabinets, finding two or three more towels to add to her stack)* It's not for my hair, Mama. Where's Daddy's gun?

THELMA: In the attic. *(Jessie goes off stage – to attic)* One of his shoeboxes, I think . . . What do you want the gun for, Jess?

JESSIE: Protection.

THELMA: I don't like the idea of a gun, Jess.

JESSIE: **(Pg 12)** *(calling down from the attic)* Which shoebox, do you remember?

THELMA: You come down from there before you have a fit. I can't come up and get you, you know.

JESSIE: Here it is. I found it. *(trying to be calm)* **(Pg 13-14** The gun is for me. I'm going to kill myself, Mama.

THELMA: *(going to the sofa)* Very funny. Very funny.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JESSIE: I am.

THELMA: *(quickly, irritated)* You are not! Don't even say such a thing, Jessie.

JESSIE: How would you know if I didn't say it? You want it to be a surprise? You're lying there in your bed or maybe you're just brushing your teeth and you hear this . . . noise down the hall?

THELMA: Kill yourself.

JESSIE: Shoot myself. In a couple of hours.

THELMA: It must be time for your medicine.

JESSIE: Took it already.

THELMA: Then what's the matter with you?

JESSIE: Not a thing. Feel fine.

THELMA: You feel fine. You're just going to kill yourself.

JESSIE: Waited until I felt good enough, in fact.

THELMA: Don't make jokes, Jessie. I'm too old for jokes.

JESSIE: It's not a joke, Mama. *(Mama watches for a moment in silence)*

THELMA: **(Pg 16 – 17)** We're just going to sit around like every other night in the world and then you're going to kill yourself? *(Jessie doesn't answer)* You'll miss. *(again, no response)* You'll just wind up a vegetable. How would you like that? You know what the doctor said about getting excited. You'll cock the pistol and have a fit.

JESSIE: I think I can kill myself, Mama.

THELMA: You're not going to kill yourself, Jessie. You're not even upset! *(Jessie smiles, or laughs quietly, and Mama tries a different approach)* People don't really kill themselves, Jessie. No, Ma'am, doesn't make sense, unless you're deranged and you're as normal as they come, Jessie, for the most part.

JESSIE: It's exactly what I want. It's dark and quiet.

THELMA: So is the back yard, Jessie! Close your eyes. Stuff cotton in your ears. Take a nap!

JESSIE: So quiet I don't know it's quiet. So nobody can get me. Dead is everybody and everything I ever knew, gone. Dead is dead quiet.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

THELMA: It's a sin. You'll go to hell.

JESSIE: Uh-huh.

THELMA: You will! *(Jessie doesn't answer. She puts the now loaded gun back in the box and crosses to the kitchen. But Mama is afraid she is headed for the bedroom. In a panic)* You can't use my towels! They're my towels. I've had them for a long time. I like my towels. And you can't use your father's gun either. It's mine now too. And you can't do it in my house.

JESSIE: Oh, come on. If I'd known you were going to act like this. I wouldn't have told you.

THELMA: How am I supposed to act? Tell you to go ahead? O. K. by me, sugar. Might try it myself. What took you so long?

JESSIE: There's just no point in fighting me over it, that's all. Want some coffee?

THELMA: **(Pg 21)** Your eyes don't look right. I thought so yesterday.

JESSIE: That was just the ragweed. I'm not sick.

THELMA: Epilepsy is sick, Jessie.

JESSIE: It won't kill me. *(a pause)* If it would. I wouldn't have to.

THELMA: You don't ***have*** to.

JESSIE: No, I don't. That's what I like about it. Mama . . . **(Pg 22)** I'm just not having a very good time and I don't have any reason to think it'll get anything but worse. I'm tired. I'm hurt. I'm sad. I feel used.

THELMA: Tired of what?

JESSIE: It all.

THELMA: What does that mean?

JESSIE: I can't say it any better.

THELMA: Well, you'll have to say it better because I'm not letting you alone til you do. How long have you been thinking about this?

JESSIE: Off and on, ten years. On all the time, since Christmas.

THELMA: **(Pg 24)** You're feeling sorry for yourself! You're not having a good time! Whoever promised you a good time? Do you think I've had a good time? **(Pg 25-26)** You're acting like some little brat, Jessie. You're mad you're miserable and it's your own sweet fault.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JESSIE: And it's time I did something about it.

THELMA: Not something like killing yourself.

JESSIE: I'll do whatever you want before I go.

THELMA: *(badly frightened by those words)* You could get a job!

JESSIE: You know I couldn't work. I can't do anything. I've never been around people my whole life except when I went to the hospital. I could have a seizure any time. What good would a job do? The kind of job I could get would make me feel worse. *(taking charge of this)* **(Pg 43-44)** What do they look like? The seizures.

THELMA: *(reluctant)* Different each time, Jess. There's not much to tell. You just . . . crumple, in a heap, like a puppet and somebody cut the strings all at once, you just slide down the wall, you know.

JESSIE: My head turns around and I fall down and then what?

THELMA: Well, your chest squeezes in and out and you sound like you're gagging, sucking air in and out like you can't breathe.

JESSIE: Do it for me. Make the sound for me.

THELMA: I will not. It's awful sounding.

JESSIE: Yeah. It felt like it might be. What's next.

THELMA: Then you turn blue and the jerks start up. Like I'm standing there poking you with a cattle prod. And then the jerks slow down and you wet yourself and it's over. Two minutes tops. *(then making a real effort)* But Jessie, you haven't had a seizure for a solid year. A whole year, do you realize that?

JESSIE: Yeah, the phenobarb's about right now, I guess. I sure am feeling good. I really am. The double vision's gone and my gums aren't swelling. No rashes or anything. I'm feeling as good as I ever felt in my life. I'm even feeling like worrying or getting mad and I'm not afraid it will start a fit if I do. I just go ahead.

THELMA: Of course you do! You can even scream at me, if you want to. I can take it. You don't have to act like you're just visiting here, Jessie, this is your house too.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JESSIE: The best part is my memory's back. *(folding the rest of the laundry)* **(Pg 45)** Yes, Mama. Once I started remembering, I could see what it all added up to.

THELMA: **(Pg 47)** *(beginning to break down)* Maybe I fed you the wrong thing. Maybe you had a fever some time and I didn't know it soon enough. Maybe it's a punishment.

JESSIE: For what?

THELMA: I don't know. Because of how I felt about your father. Because I didn't want any more children. Because I smoked too much or didn't eat right when I was carrying you. It has to be something I did.

JESSIE: It does not. It's just a sickness, not a curse. Epilepsy doesn't mean anything. It just is.

THELMA: I'm not talking about the fits here, Jessie! I'm talking about this killing yourself. It has to be me that's the matter here. . . I don't know what I did, but I did it, I know. This is all my fault, Jessie, but I can't do anything about it!

JESSIE: **(Pg 26)** *(quietly)* No. You can't. *(Mama slumps, if not physically, at least emotionally)* And I can't do anything either, about my life, to change it, make it better, make it work. But I can stop it. Shut it down, turn it off like the radio when there's nothing on I want to listen to. It's all I really have that belongs to me and I'm going to say what happens to it. And it's going to stop. I'm going to stop it.

THELMA: **(Pg 47-48)** Everything you do has to do with me, Jessie. You can't do ***anything***, wash your face or cut your finger, without doing it to me. That's right! You might as well kill me as you, Jessie, it's the same thing. This has to do with me, Jessie.

JESSIE: Then what if it does! What if it has everything to do with you! What if you are all I have and you're not enough? What if I could take all the rest of it if only I didn't have you here? What if the only way I can get away from you for good is to kill myself? What if it is? I can ***still*** do it!

THELMA: *(in desperate tears)* Don't leave me, Jessie! *(Jessie stands for a moment, then turns for the bedroom)* No! *(grabs her arm)* Jessie, how can I . . . *(has to stop a moment.)* How can I get up every day knowing you had to kill yourself to make it stop hurting and I was here all

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the time and I never even saw it. And then you gave me this chance to make it better, convince you to stay alive and I couldn't do it. How can I live with myself after this, Jessie?

JESSIE: I only told you so I could explain it, so you wouldn't blame yourself. There wasn't anything you could say to change my mind. I didn't want you to save me. I just wanted you to know.

THELMA: Stay with me just a little longer. Just a few more years. I don't have that many more to go, Jessie. And as soon as I'm dead, you can do whatever you want.

JESSIE: **(Pg 49)** Don't you see, Mama, everything I do winds up like this. How could I think you would understand? We could hold hands for an hour and then I could go shoot myself? I'm sorry about tonight, Mama, but it's exactly why I'm doing it.

THELMA: If you've got the guts to kill yourself, Jessie, you've got the guts to stay alive.

JESSIE: I know that. So it's really just a matter of where I'd rather be.

THELMA: Look, maybe I can't think of what you should do, but that doesn't mean there isn't something that would help. You can keep trying. You can get brave and try some more. You don't have to give up!

JESSIE: I'm ***not*** giving up! This ***is*** the other thing I'm trying. And I'm sure there are some other things that might work, but ***might*** work isn't good enough anymore. I need something that ***will*** work. ***This*** will work. That's why I picked it.

THELMA: **(Pg 50-52)** You are my child!

JESSIE: I am what became of your child. *(Mama cannot answer)* I found an old baby picture of me. And it was somebody else, not me. It was somebody pink and fat who never heard of sick or lonely, somebody who cried and got fed, and reached up and got held. That's who I started out and this is who is left. *(no self-pity here)* That's what this is about. It's somebody I lost, all right, it's my own self. Who I never was. Or who I tried to be and never got there. Somebody I waited for who never came. And never will. I'm what was worth waiting for and I didn't make it. Me . . . who might have made a difference to me . . . I'm not going to show up, so there's no reason to stay, except to keep you company, and that's . . . not reason enough.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

THELMA: *(quickly)* Jessie**,** I can't just sit here and say O. K., kill yourself if you want to. *(Jessie turns away)* Who am I talking to? You're gone already, aren't you? I can't stop you because you're already gone! *(beat, a different tactic)* Well, nobody's going to be a bit surprised, sweetheart. This is just like you. Do it the hard way, that's my girl all right. *(Jessie gets up and goes into the kitchen, but Mama follows her.)* You know who they're going to feel sorry for? Me! How about that! Not you, me! They're going to be ***ashamed*** of you. Yes. ***Ashamed***!

JESSIE: Leave me alone.

THELMA: It's the truth!

JESSIE: I should've just left you a note!

THELMA: *(screaming)* Yes! *(then suddenly understanding what she has said, nearly paralyzed by the thought of it, she turns slowly to face Jessie, nearly whispering)* No. No. I . . . might not have thought of all the things you've said.

JESSIE: It's O. K., Mama. *(beat)* **(Pg 53)** Now, somebody's bound to ask you why I did it and you just say you don't know. That you loved me and you know I loved you and we just sat around tonight like every other night of our lives and then I came over and kissed you and said, " 'Night, Mother," and you heard me close my bedroom door and the next thing you heard was the shot.

THELMA: *(quietly)* It was something personal.

JESSIE: Good. That's good, Mama. *(standing behind Mama now, holding her shoulders)* **(Pg 54)** Now, when you hear the shot, I don't want you to come in. First of all, you won't be able to get in by yourself, but I don't want you trying. Call the police. And then you'll need something to do til somebody gets here, so wash the hot chocolate pan. You wash that pan til you hear the doorbell ring and I don't care if it's an hour, you keep washing that pan.

THELMA: I'll make my calls and then I'll just sit. I won't need something to do.

JESSIE: **(Pg 56- 58)** It's time for me to go, Mama.

THELMA: *(starting to her)* No, Jessie, you've got all night! *(grabs her)* It's not even ten o'clock.

JESSIE: *(very calm)* Let me go, Mama.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

THELMA: I can't. You can't go. You can't do this. You didn't say it would be so soon, Jessie. I'm scared. I love you.

JESSIE: *(takes her hands away)* Let go of me, Mama. I've said everything I had to say. Don't try and stop me, Mama, you can't do it.

THELMA: *(grabs her again, this time hard)* I can too! I'll stand in front of this hall and you can't get past me. *(they struggle)* You'll have to knock me down to get away from me, Jessie, I'm not about to let you . . . *(in the struggle, Jessie gets away from her)*

JESSIE: *(almost a whisper)* 'Night, Mother. *(Jessie vanishes into her bedroom and locks the door just as Mama gets to it)*

THELMA: *(screams)* JESSIE! *(pounds on the door)* Jessie! Stop this! I didn't know! I was here with you all the time. How could I know you were so alone? *(stops for a moment, breathless and frantic, putting her ear to the door and when she doesn't hear anything, she stands back up straight again and screams once more)* Jessie! Please! *(gunshot -- Mama collapses against the door, tears streaming down her face)* Jessie, Jessie, child . . . Forgive me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Marsha Norman
ISBN: 978-0374521387
Publisher: Noonday Press
Date (Month/Year): Aug 1983

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
2020 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier
SD State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY